

RH14

Social Life: Fairs, Festivals, Customs, Dress, Ornaments, Tribes

About 2-3 questions a paper. Ornament-to-body-part and fair-to-district are near-certain; costume terms were asked in 2012, 2021 and 2024; fairs in 2013, 2016 and 2023; tribes appear in most papers.

The most learnable chapter in the paper. Almost every question here is a match — fair to district, festival to tithi, ornament to body part, tribe to region. There is very little to understand and a great deal to memorise correctly, which is exactly why careless students lose these marks.

Social Life of Rajasthan

Cattle fairs

- Pushkar — Ajmer, Kartik
- Mallinath — Tilwara, oldest
- Tejaji — Parbatsar
- Chandrabhaga — Jhalrapatan

Customs

- Jalwa Pujan, Jadula
- Sagai, Bindoli, Toran, Pheras
- Mausar / Nukta
- Nata, Aata-Sata, Dapa

Tribes

- Meena (largest), Bhil (2nd), Garasia (3rd)
- Sahariya — only PVTG, Baran
- Damor, Kathodi, Kanjar, Sansi
- Rabari, Gadia Lohar

Deity & tribal fairs

- Ramdevra — Jaisalmer
- Kaila Devi — Karauli
- Beneshwar — Dungarpur, tribal Kumbh
- Sitabari — Baran, Sahariya

Dress

- Angarkhi, Atamsukh, Dogla
- Pagri: Amarshahi, Shahjahani, Khidkidar
- Ghaghra, Kanchli, Kachhabu, Odhna
- Pomcha, Lehariya, Mothra, Kasumal

Festivals

- Gangaur — Chaitra Shukla 3
- Hariyali & Kajali Teej
- Akha Teej, Dhinga Gavar
- Ghudla, Sanjhi

Ornaments

- Rakhdi / Borla — head
- Toti — ear
- Timaniya — neck
- Bajuband — arm, Kandora — waist, Nevari — foot

Fairs — start with the cattle fairs

Rajasthan's fairs fall into three groups: cattle fairs, deity fairs and tribal fairs. Take the cattle fairs first, because they carry the most fixed data — a place, a district, usually a river, and a month. That is exactly the shape of an RPSC question. Learn the month along with the district; the exam has asked the closing day of Pushkar directly.

The cattle fairs

Fair	Place and district	Month and note
Pushkar	Pushkar, Ajmer	Kartik Ekadashi to Kartik Purnima; the camel fair
Mallinath	Tilwara (Balotra), on the Luni	Chaitra; the oldest cattle fair of Rajasthan
Tejaji	Parbatsar, Nagaur	Bhadrapad
Chandrabhaga	Jhalrapatan, Jhalawar, on the Chandrabhaga	Kartik Purnima
Gogamedi	Nohar, Hanumangarh	Bhadrapad Krishna Navami — Goga Navami
Kolayat	Kolayat, Bikaner	Kartik Purnima; sacred to Kapil Muni

- Pushkar holds the principal Brahma temple of India — that fact is half of every Pushkar question.
- The Malani tract of western Rajasthan takes its name from Mallinath.
- Tejaji was born at Kharnal in Nagaur, and his fair is at Parbatsar in the same district.
- The Kolayat fair falls on the same day as Pushkar's closing day, Kartik Purnima.
- Kartik Purnima is a crowded date — Pushkar, Chandrabhaga and Kolayat all end on it.
- Chaitra belongs to Mallinath, Kaila Devi, Karni Mata, Ghudla and Gangaur.
- Bhadrapad belongs to Tejaji, Gogaji, Ramdevra, Khejarli and Kajali Teej.
- Magh Purnima belongs to Beneshwar; Phalgun to Khatu Shyamji.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2016 — where is the Chandrabhaga cattle fair held? Jhalrapatan, Jhalawar. Asked in RAS Pre 2013 — where is Tejaji's great cattle fair? Parbatsar. RAS Pre 2016 also asked the closing day of the Pushkar fair (Kartik Purnima). Three cattle fairs across three papers.

Deity fairs, tribal fairs and the Muslim fairs

The deity fairs are simply the folk deities and goddesses of the previous chapter seen from the calendar side. If you already know that Ramdevra is in Jaisalmer and Kaila Devi in Karauli, you have most of this section. Fill in only the month and the distinctive detail.

Deity and pilgrim fairs

Fair	Place	District and month
Ramdevra	Ramdevra (Runicha), near Pokhran	Jaisalmer; Bhadrapad Shukla 2 to 11
Kaila Devi 'Lakhi' mela	Trikut hills, on the Kalisil	Karauli; Chaitra Shukla Ashtami
Karni Mata	Deshnok	Bikaner; Chaitra and Ashwin Navratri
Khatu Shyamji	Khatu	Sikar; Phalgun
Mahaveerji	Chandangaon, Hindaun, on the Gambhir	Karauli
Ghushmeshwar	Shivad	Sawai Madhopur; reckoned the twelfth jyotirlinga
Sheetla Mata	Sheel ki Doongri, Chaksu	Jaipur; Chaitra Krishna Ashtami
Khejarli	Khejarli	Jodhpur; Bhadrapad Shukla Dashami
Dadu mela	Naraina	Jaipur; seat of the Dadu Panth

The tribal fairs and the two great urs

- Beneshwar — at Sabla/Navatapura in Dungarpur, at the confluence of the Som, Mahi and Jakham, on Magh Purnima; called the 'Kumbh of the tribals (Bhils)'.
- Sitabari — at Kelwara in Baran; the great fair of the Sahariyas.

- Urs of Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti — Ajmer, 1 to 6 Rajab.
- Galiakot urs — Dungarpur, of the Dawoodi Bohras, at the dargah of Syed Fakhruddin.
- Sheetla Mata is worshipped in a broken idol; her vehicle is the donkey and her priests are drawn from the Kumhar caste.
- Khejarli's fair commemorates the 363 Vishnoi tree-martyrs of 1730 led by Amrita Devi.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2023 — the Beneshwar fair, the 'Kumbh of the tribals', is in which district? Dungarpur. RPSC's favourite NOT-matched trap in this list is Mallinath: the fair is at Tilwara near Balotra on the Luni, and the wrong option offered is Jaisalmer.

Gangaur and Teej — the pair the exam actually decides on

Both are women's festivals, both fall on a Tritiya, both are about Parvati. That is precisely why RPSC puts them together and swaps their months. Fix four coordinates: Gangaur is Chaitra, Teej is Shravan or Bhadrapad; Hariyali Teej belongs to Jaipur, Kajali Teej belongs to Bundi. And remember the Rajasthani saying, because it has itself been used as a statement.

Gangaur vs Teej

Gangaur	Teej
Chaitra Shukla Tritiya — eighteen days after Holi	Hariyali Teej: Shravan Shukla Tritiya. Kajali (Badi) Teej: Bhadrapad Krishna Tritiya
Worship of Isar (Shiva) and Gauri (Parvati)	Worship of Parvati; the monsoon and swing festival
Jaipur's Gangaur procession is the most famous	Hariyali Teej is Jaipur's; Kajali Teej is Bundi's
Variants: Gulabi Gangaur at Nathdwara, DHINGA GAVAR at Jodhpur	Teej sawari begins the festival season
Ends the festival year	Begins the festival year

- The saying: 'Teej tyoharan ri shuruat, Gangaur tyoharan ro ant' — Teej starts the festival cycle, Gangaur ends it.
- Gulabi (Pink) Gangaur is the distinctive Gangaur of Nathdwara in Rajsamand district.
- DHINGA GAVAR is celebrated at Jodhpur in Vaishakh, just after Gangaur; women in disguise take over the streets, one of the very few Indian festivals led entirely by women.
- Ghudla belongs to Marwar, in Chaitra — girls carry a perforated earthen pot with a lamp burning inside and sing Ghudla songs.

TRAP

'Kajali Teej is celebrated at Jaipur in Shravan' — FALSE, and RPSC writes it exactly like that. Kajali (Badi) Teej is Bundi's and falls in Bhadrapad Krishna. Jaipur's is Hariyali Teej, Shravan Shukla. One city, one month each — do not merge them.

ASKED IN RAS

The research digest lists Gulabi Gangaur among the fairs-and-festivals repeats of 2013, 2016 and 2023, alongside Pushkar, Beneshwar, Chandrabhaga and Tejaji. The Gulabi Gangaur question has only one answer: Nathdwara, Rajsamand. Do not write Jodhpur — Jodhpur is Dyinga Gavar.

The rest of the festival calendar

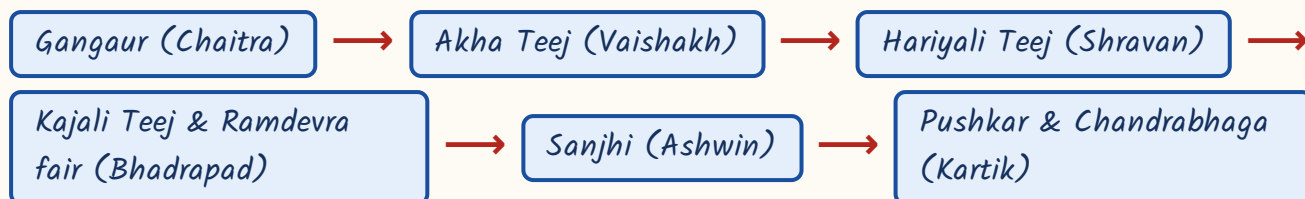
Beyond Gangaur and Teej, the exam wants festival-to-tithi matching and, occasionally, an ordering question. Both are solved the same way: memorise the Vikram Samvat month for each festival and then run the months in order.

Festival to tithi

Festival	Tithi / month	Note
Gangaur	Chaitra Shukla Tithiya	Isar and Gauri
Ghudla	Chaitra	Marwar; perforated pot with a lamp
Sheetla Ashtami	Chaitra Krishna Ashtami	Chaksu fair; cold food eaten
Akha Teej / Akshaya Tithiya	Vaishakh Shukla Tithiya	An 'abuj' muhurat; traditionally the child-marriage season
Dyinga Gavar	Vaishakh	Jodhpur
Nirjala Ekadashi	Jyeshtha Shukla Ekadashi	The waterless fast
Hariyali Teej	Shravan Shukla Tithiya	Jaipur
Kajali (Badi) Teej	Bhadrapad Krishna Tithiya	Bundi
Goga Navami	Bhadrapad Krishna Navami	Gogamedi fair
Ramdev Jayanti / Ramdevra fair	Bhadrapad Shukla 2 to 11	Jaisalmer
Sanjhi	Ashwin Krishna Paksha (Pitru Paksha)	Cow-dung wall art made by girls; ends with immersion
Pushkar, Chandrabhaga, Kolayat	Kartik Purnima	The three Kartik fairs

Festival	Tithi / month	Note
Makar Sankranti	Mid-January, when the sun enters Capricorn	Kite flying, especially at Jaipur

The festival year in order, beginning with Chaitra



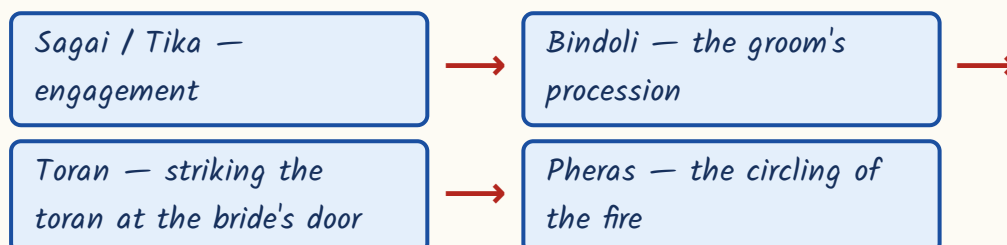
YAAD RAKHO

Fix the Vikram Samvat month order once and every ordering question in this chapter solves itself: Chaitra, Vaishakh, Jyeshtha, Ashadh, Shravan, Bhadrapad, Ashwin, Kartik, Margashirsha, Paush, Magh, Phalgun. The year starts in Chaitra, not January.

Customs — birth, marriage and death

The exam asks these as vocabulary: it gives a Rajasthani word and asks what it means, or gives four word-meaning pairs and asks which is wrong. So learn the word first and the ritual second. Group them by stage of life — that is how you stop confusing them.

The marriage sequence



- Jalwa Pujan — the mother worships a well or water source a few days after childbirth.

- Jadula (Mundan) — the child's first tonsure. Dhundh — a birth-related celebration for the newborn boy.
 - Mausar (Mosar) and Nukta — the community feast given after a death; long criticised as a cause of rural indebtedness.
 - Nata pratha — a woman goes to live with another man after a settlement, usually a money payment.
 - Aata-Sata — exchange marriage, where two families exchange brides. Do not confuse it with Nata.
 - Dapa — the bride price paid among the Garasia, Sahariya and Damor tribes.
 - Talak — the customary term for separation in some communities.
-
- Kanyavarodh — the practice that kept girls from marrying outside a narrow circle, driving up dowry demands and, in extreme form, feeding female infanticide.
 - The Walterkrit Rajputana Hitkarini Sabha (1888, Ajmer) was set up largely to curb Kanyavarodh, extravagant marriage expenditure and Mausar.
 - This is the link between this chapter and the 19th-century reform chapter — RPSC has asked the Walterkrit Sabha directly, in 2024.
 - Sati was abolished in Bundi in 1822 and across Rajputana in 1844; the Tyaga and Dakan customs were struck down at Udaipur in 1853.

Dress — men's and women's terms

Two kinds of question come from dress. One is a plain vocabulary question ('Atamsukh is what?'). The other is a colour or textile question, and there Kasumal, Lehariya and Mothra are the repeats. Keep the men's list and the women's list separate in your head; RPSC's wrong option is usually a women's garment slipped into a men's list.

- Men: Dhoti, Angarkha/Angarkhi (upper garment), Atamsukh (long padded winter coat), Dogla, Patka, Mojari.
 - Pagri styles: Amarshahi (after Maharana Amar Singh of Mewar), Shahjahani, Khidkidar, Udaishahi, Rajshahi, Jodhpuri safa.
 - Kachhabu is a woman's upper garment, NOT a turban style — RPSC has used it as the wrong option in a pagri list.
 - Poti and Chirmi are among the other named cloth items of the traditional wardrobe.
-
- Women: Ghaghra (the pleated skirt), Kanchli/Kurti (the bodice), Kachhabu (upper garment), Odhna/Chunari (the veil).
 - Pomcha — a yellow odhni printed with lotus motifs, traditionally given and worn on the birth of a child.
 - Lehariya — diagonal wave-like stripes, worn in the Teej and Shravan season. It is NOT concentric circles.
 - Mothra — lehariya tied diagonally in both directions, producing a criss-cross check.
 - Bandhej — the tie-and-dye craft; Jodhpur, Jaipur and Sikar are noted centres.
 - Kasumal — a deep red or crimson, named after kusum, safflower, from which the dye was obtained.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 — 'Kasumal', a colour used in Rajasthani costume, is what? Answer: deep red or crimson, from safflower. The research digest groups Kasumal with Toti as a costume-and-ornament repeat cluster of 2012, 2021 and 2024, so expect one question from this pair of topics every paper.

Ornaments — the most directly asked table in the chapter

RPSC asks this as bluntly as a question can be asked: 'On which part of the body is X worn?' There is no reasoning involved and no partial credit. Learn the body part and nothing else. Read the table downwards once, then cover the right column and recall it.

Ornaments of the head and upper body

Body part	Ornaments
Head	Rakhdi / Borla, Sheeshphool, Memand, Tikda
Ear	Toti, Jhumka, Surliya, Bali
Nose	Nath, Nathdi, Bhanwariya, Laung
Neck	Timaniya, Hansli, Kanthi, Aad, Hamel, Madaliya

Ornaments of the arm, waist and foot

Body part	Ornaments
Arm and hand	Bajuband (upper arm), Chuda, Gajra, Pahunchi, Hathphool
Waist	Kandora, Kardhani, Tagdi
Foot	Payal, Nevari, Kadi, Anwala, Bichhiya, Rimjhol

YAAD RAKHO

Seven anchors and this topic is finished: Rakhdi head, Toti ear, Nathdi nose, Timaniya neck, Bajuband arm, Kandora waist, Nevari foot. One warning — Anwala sounds like an arm word but it is a hollow circular ornament worn on the FOOT. Rakhdi/Borla is also the mark of a married woman.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2021 — on which part of the body is 'Toti' worn?

Answer: the ear. RPSC's match version in the same family runs

Sheeshphool-head, Bhanwariya-nose, Bajuband-upper arm, Nevari-foot, and its NOT-matched version has used Anwala, which belongs to the foot.

Tribes — the framework, and Bhil against Mina

Start with the population order, because a wrong assumption here poisons three or four questions. Scheduled Tribes are 13.48 per cent of Rajasthan's population by Census 2011. The order is Meena first, Bhil second, Garasia third. Sahariya is the only PVTG in the state — but being the most vulnerable does not make it the largest or the second largest, and that gap is exactly where RPSC sets its trap.

- Census 2011: Scheduled Tribes are 13.48 per cent of Rajasthan's population.
- Meena is the largest ST, about 47 per cent of the state's ST population.
- Bhil is second, about 44 per cent. Garasia is third.
- Sahariya is the only Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Group of Rajasthan, but is not among the top three by population.
- The Tribal Area Development (TAD) department has its headquarters at Udaipur.

Bhil vs Mina

Bhil	Mina (Meena)
Southern Rajasthan — Banswara, Dungarpur, Udaipur, Pratapgarh	Eastern Rajasthan
Second largest ST, about 44 per cent of the ST population	Largest ST, about 47 per cent of the ST population
Village head: Gameti. Hamlet: Phala. Group of hamlets: Pal	Divided into Zamindar Mina and Chowkidar Mina
Shifting cultivation called Walra — Chimata on hill slopes, Dajiya on the plains	Settled cultivators; described as the most educated tribe of the state
Dances: Gawari (Rai) in Shravan-Bhadrapad in Mewar, and Ghoomar	Meena Kshatriya Mahasabha founded 1933; removed from the Criminal Tribes list in 1952
Called the 'bowmen of India'; Beneshwar is their Kumbh	The Chowkidar Minas served traditionally as village watchmen

- The Bhil settlement ladder, in order: Phala (hamlet) to Pal (group of hamlets) to the village under the Gameti.
- Walra is the name of the shifting-cultivation practice as a whole.
- Bhil tribal movements — Govind Giri, the Samp Sabha and Mangarh 1913 — belong to the movements chapter but the same tribe.
- Mina headmen are not called Gameti; Gameti is Bhil, Mukhi is Damor, Kotwal is Sahariya.

TRAP

Chimata is on the HILL SLOPES; Dajiya is on the PLAINS. RPSC has run this as a two-statement question with the terms reversed, and both statements were wrong. Say it once, correctly: Chimata-Chadhai (slope), Dajiya-Dharti (plain).

The smaller tribes and the nomadic communities

For each of the smaller tribes the exam wants three things: the district, the word for the headman, and one distinctive custom or dance. Nothing more. Read the table as three columns of vocabulary, not as ethnography.

Tribe to area to headman and distinctive terms

Tribe	Main area	Headman and distinctive terms
Bhil	Banswara, Dungarpur, Udaipur, Pratapgarh	Gameti; Phala, Pal; Walra cultivation; Gawari dance
Mina	Eastern Rajasthan	Zamindar Mina and Chowkidar Mina; Mahasabha 1933
Garasia	Abu Road and Pindwara (Sirohi), Bali (Pali), Gogunda and Kotra (Udaipur)	House 'Gher', hamlet 'Faliya'; marriages Mor Bandhiya, Peharavana, Tanana; bride price 'Dapa'; Valar/Gaur dance
Sahariya	Kishanganj and Shahbad tehsils, Baran	Headman 'Kotwal'; huts Topa, Korua, Gopna; the only PVTG; Sitabari fair
Damor	Simalwara and Aspur (Dungarpur), Banswara	Headman 'Mukhi'; the Gyaras fair
Kathodi	Kotra and Jhadol, Udaipur	Migrants from Maharashtra; make katha from khair wood; Mavlia dance
Kanjar	Hadoti region	Deities Jogania Mata, Chauth Mata, Hanuman; Chakri and Dhakad dances
Sansi	Bharatpur	Sub-groups Bija and Mala; kuldevi Sikodari Mata
Rabari / Raika	Marwar, western Rajasthan	Camel breeders; worship Pabuji
Gadia Lohar	Nomadic, across the state	Blacksmiths travelling in bullock carts; the Chittor vow

- *Gadia Lohar: they vowed not to return to Chittorgarh after its fall to Akbar in 1568; Jawaharlal Nehru led them into Chittorgarh fort in 1955.*
- *Garasia is the third largest ST and lives in the Sirohi-Pali-Udaipur belt, not in Baran and Jhalawar.*

- Kalbeliya and Bhopa are the well-known performing communities; the Kalbeliya dance was inscribed on UNESCO's Intangible Cultural Heritage list in 2010.
- Sitabari at Kelwara in Baran is the Sahariyas' sacred fair; Beneshwar in Dungarpur is the Bhils'.

TRAP

Two Sahariya half-truths RPSC has used together. The Sahariyas are the only PVTG of Rajasthan and they do live in Kishanganj and Shahbad in Baran — but they are NOT the second largest tribe; the Bhils are. And on the Gadia Lohars, the vow was about CHITTORGARH, not Jodhpur, and it was NEHRU, not Patel, who led them into the fort in 1955.

CURRENT LINK

Current link (as of September 2026): PM-JANMAN, the Pradhan Mantri Janjati Adivasi Nyaya Maha Abhiyan, was launched on 15 November 2023 with about Rs 24,104 crore over three years for India's PVTGs, with roughly 80 per cent going to housing and roads. In Rajasthan it means exactly one community — the Sahariyas of Kishanganj and Shahbad in Baran, who have been getting housing, road connectivity and electrification under it. Expect 'the only PVTG of Rajasthan' to arrive dressed as a scheme question rather than a tribes question.

REVISION RECAP

1. Pushkar — Ajmer, Kartik Ekadashi to Purnima, camel fair, India's principal Brahma temple.
2. Mallinath at Tilwara (Balotra) on the Luni, Chaitra — the oldest cattle fair; Chandrabhaga at Jhalrapatan, Jhalawar, Kartik Purnima.
3. Tejaji fair — Parbatsar, Nagaur, Bhadrapad; Gogamedi — Nohar, Hanumangarh; Kolayat — Bikaner, Kartik Purnima, Kapil Muni.

4. Beneshwar — Sabla, Dungarpur, Som-Mahi-Jakham confluence, Magh Purnima, the tribal Kumbh; Sitabari — Kelwara, Baran, the Sahariya fair.
5. Kaila Devi Lakhi mela — Karauli, Chaitra Shukla Ashtami; Ramdevra — Jaisalmer, Bhadrapad Shukla 2-11; Khatu Shyamji — Sikar, Phalgun.
6. Ghushmeshwar at Shivad (Sawai Madhopur) is reckoned the twelfth jyotirlinga; Sheetla Mata at Chaksu has a broken idol, a donkey vehicle and Kumhar priests.
7. Gangaur — Chaitra Shukla Tritiya, Isar and Gauri; Gulabi Gangaur at Nathdwara; Dhingra Gavar at Jodhpur in Vaishakh.
8. Hariyali Teej is Jaipur's, Shravan Shukla Tritiya; Kajali Teej is Bundi's, Bhadrapad Krishna Tritiya. Teej starts the festival year, Gangaur ends it.
9. Akha Teej — Vaishakh Shukla Tritiya, an abuj muhurat; Sanjhi — Ashwin Krishna Paksha; Ghudla — Marwar, Chaitra.
10. Jalwa Pujan is well worship after childbirth; Jadula is the mundan; Mausar and Nukta are death feasts; Nata is remarriage by settlement; Dapa is bride price.
11. Men: Angarkhi, Atamsukh (winter coat), Dogla, Patka. Pagri styles Amarshahi, Shahjahani, Khidkidar, Udaishahi.
12. Women: Ghaghra, Kanchli, Kachhabu, Odhna. Pomcha is the yellow lotus odhni for a childbirth; Lehariya is diagonal stripes; Mothra is lehariya both ways.
13. Kasumal is deep red/crimson from kusum, safflower — RAS Pre 2024.
14. Ornaments: Rakhdi/Borla head, Toti ear, Nathdi nose, Timaniya neck, Bajuband arm, Kandora waist, Nevari and Anwala foot.
15. STs are 13.48% of Rajasthan (Census 2011); order Meena (about 47%) > Bhil (about 44%) > Garasia.
16. Bhil: Gameti, Phala, Pal, Walra — Chimata on slopes, Dajiya on plains; Gawari dance; bowmen of India.
17. Sahariya is the only PVTG, Baran, headman Kotwal, huts Topa/Korua/Gopna; Damor headman Mukhi; Garasia bride price Dapa, dance Valar.
18. Kathodi — Udaipur, katha from khair; Kanjar — Hadoti; Sansi — Bharatpur; Rabari/Raika — camel breeders of Marwar; Gadia Lohar — Chittor vow 1568, Nehru 1955; TAD headquarters at Udaipur.